

The Miracles of 626

Prospective Player Guide, Costume Guide, and Character List

Document Prepared by Dr. Joy DowlingSoka for the Miracles of 626 Team
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Facing Image: Copper Coin Depicting Herakleios, Martina, and Herakleios Konstantinos from 626 CE. Image from vcoins.

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Prospective Player Guide

Χαίρετε! Welcome! Welcome to the City!

This magnificence all around you is Konstantinoupolis, the most important city in the world! The centre of the world!

Where we stand now is the Forum, the centre of political life. This is where everyone rubs shoulders and is the stage for our civic drama.

Here you can find anything! The best markets, the biggest dramas, the largest spectacles, and, on a bad day… the deadliest riots. Be careful here at night, the statues attract the demonic old gods… but maybe you are into that?

Over that way is the Great Church, you can see its Dome! There you will find the centre of Christianity. The most important rituals, the most powerful relics, and the largest library in the city.

Across from the church, you can see the great palace! The home of royalty and the very political centre of our Roman world. I'm told it is unimaginably luxurious, mosaic floors, silk clothing, private baths, all the best food… maybe… if I am lucky, I will enter it one day!

Beside the palace, you can see the Hippodromos! The grand chariot races take place there. You absolutely must attend one while you are here! Just be careful not to bet too heavily, the races are controlled by the Venetoi and Prassini. They are… cutthroat in their business and, if you ask me… actually are the ones who run this place. I do not recommend owing them money.

And then, of course, you have the city itself in all its strangeness! Tens of thousands of people live here, spread throughout our many winding streets. Here in the Sphorakiou we have the richest of the rich, the families that at one point or another ruled the Empire. Over there, in the Oxeia, you have the crowded centre of the city, the places that even the poorest find a place to sleep. Whatever your background, your status, this city will take you in and keep you. We are always welcoming to strangers.

The war? Okh! Why would you ask about the war? Do you not know, the City is protected by Maria, the mother of God, and the most impressive walls ever built! The war may rage outside, but it will stay there… Surely, there will be no war here.

But… Never mind that! Welcome, welcome! Enjoy Konstantinoupolis!

Description the Miracles of 626 CE:

The Miracles of 626 is designed as an immersive educational LARP with Out of Character consent centred design. It asks players to immerse themselves in a historical research-based setting and scenario and play characters based on real biographical research. While the initial scenario is heavily historical, players are invited to chart their own course through it and the plot will respond to player decisions. The players can collaborate to tell a very different story than the historical events!



Figure 1 Events of 626 CE, Miniature 42 from Konstantinos Manasses Chronicle, 14th century. Wikimedia.

Code of Conduct

Ticket holders agree to abide by the following code of conduct. The following are adapted from Adelaide Roleplaying Community's work, we are grateful for the work they have done to make games safer.

- Respect the rights, dignity and worth of others, in private and in public.
- Respect and support other people's consent and boundaries, including the boundaries of game organisers. No means no and look for enthusiastic OOC consent to planned narratives and scenes.
- Be considerate of other people's backgrounds, even when we do not understand them.
- Accept responsibility for our actions at all times, especially when they hurt people.
- Be aware of our own mental health and wellbeing and be proactive in caring for ourselves.
- Listen and change our behaviour when we say or do something hurtful, regardless of our intentions.
- Respect and support players who are distressed, where possible, and be willing to pause our activities when needed.
- Pursue disagreements through appropriate channels.
- Be respectful of private information that is shared with us, especially as pertains to health, disability, mental illness, trauma, and sexuality or gender identity.
- Address issues and concerns we may have with Game Runners and Immersive Arts Melbourne or with other players in a reasonable manner.
- Comply with relevant laws and abide by rules, regulations and policies set by Immersive Arts Melbourne.

Generous Play

Ticket holders also agree to play generously. This manifesto has been adapted from the Dance of Ribbons Collective Generous Play Manifesto. We are grateful for the amazing things they have done introducing play to lift and generous play culture to Victoria.

- Generosity describes a readiness to give. Being a generous player is winning. Generous play is good play.
- Play is always voluntary. Have gratitude for the boundaries of others.
- Where possible, be inviting. Make interesting situations happen. If you can't make, seek out. If you can't seek, be open to interesting situations. Be inviting, accept invitation.

- Understand that you are only one character in a collective story. Work to make others look good and know that they are making you look good too.
- Your backstory is not your character, it only shapes them. Be open to responding to the unexpected!
- Your character can and should change. Be surprised by your own character's actions.
- Failure is an integral part of your character's story. Failure will define your character. Do not expect to "win" in every encounter or moment. There is no way to Win the Miracles of 626 CE.
- Trust your GM's. Do your best to be trustworthy yourself. If trust is impossible, distance yourself and seek conflict resolution through appropriate channels.
- Your mental and physical safety is more important than the game. There will not be OOC consequences for taking an OOC break.
- Remember that you and everyone else are playing characters and keep the actions of players separate from actions of characters.
- It is always ok to take a step away or to remove yourself from a situation.



Figure 2 Lead Seal of Sergios, depicting Maria and Christos. Dumbarton Oaks Seals Catalogue.

Themes definitely included in this LARP:

Heavy Religious (Early Christian, Mithraic, and Traditional Hellenistic) themes

Heavy occult themes

Horror elements, including possession.

Siege narratives including existential threats to entire city.

Violent themes and potential for graphic violent scenes.

Sexual themes, including characters involved in sex work.

Systemically misogynistic social structures. These are portrayed critically.

Complex and often fluid gender identities in a historical setting very different from modernity.

Arranged Marriages and history of royal cousin marriages.

High-stakes political intrigue

Death, hauntings, and potential resurrections.

Potential for Riots.

Food and water shortages in character.

Xenophobia (but not racism).

Extreme Material Inequality and unequal power dynamics.

Themes absolutely not allowed in this LARP:

Any modern versions of bigotry, including Racism,

Transphobia, Homophobia, Uncritical/modern portrayals of misogyny.

Sexual Violence or Coercion.

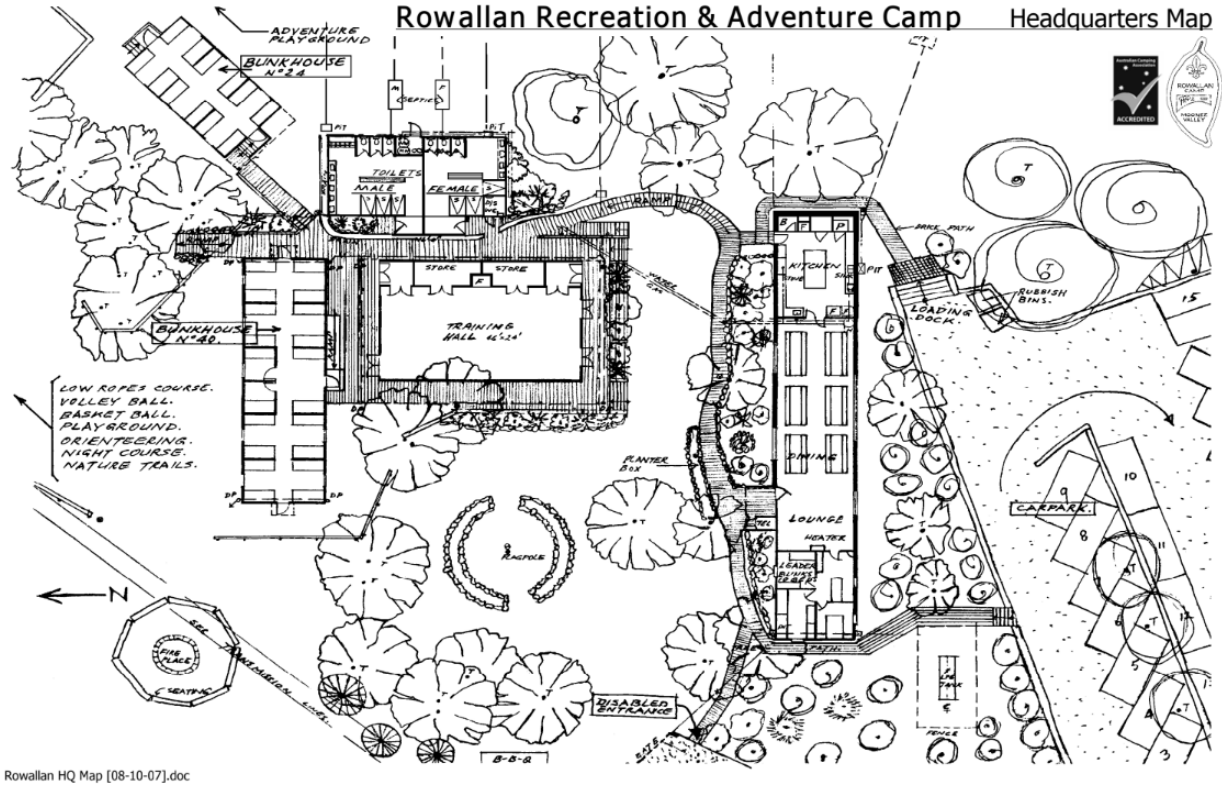
Suicide.

Underage characters.

Accessibility:

The event will be held at Rowallan Scout Camp and will provide cabin beds and meals for all participants. Accommodation for devices that need power and for allergies will be made. We will gather information on such access needs after tickets are bought. We will also have a GM doing debriefs after intense scenes.

Unfortunately, the site has a large number of steps, is on top of a hill, and has few level paths, which makes wheelchair access difficult.



The Setting:

The Miracles of 626 is set in Konstantinoupolis (modern day Istanbul) during the Avar siege of the city in 626 CE. The city is under siege by a coalition of Rome's enemies and is facing severe shortages, but there is a strong military presence, and it is unlikely (but definitely possible) that the Avars will take the city.

The ruler, Herakleios, is away in the east fighting a desperate guerrilla campaign. This has left a power vacuum in the city, and things are very unstable.

The city is a place filled with malice, mayhem, murder, and magic. All of the player characters actively want the city to survive, but many have ulterior motives that might lead them to play with fire. Whoever gets credit for surviving the siege will be well positioned to dominate politics for some time! How close to the edge of destruction will it get?

The City Regions:

The city is not homogeneous. All of the player characters live in the city, but the different districts might as well be entirely different worlds. There are not traditional factions in this game, rather the districts represent where each character sleeps at night. Each character will have their own network of contacts and social entanglements.

The Great church:

The sprawling church complex around Hagia Sophia, the largest cathedral in the world. Characters based here are clerical and engaged heavily in the religious side of the game.

The Great Palace:

The massive fortified palace that the rulers of the city have created for themselves. This is a place of ceremony and hierarchy. It is also a place of intrigue and danger. Characters here are either royal or the close servants of royals.

The Mangana:

This is the main armory of the city, it is a serious place, and the main command post for the military. Characters based here are engaged heavily with the technical aspects of the siege. They might also be called upon to restore order in the city, but this will risk disaster.

The Sphorakiou:

This is the part of the city that the rich people live in. Large villae and public baths dominate the landscape, and the shortages of the war have not reached here. The people who live

here are well off, and many come from senatorial families. It is dominated by the Venetoi, a sports team and mafia, that controls much of the city.

The Oxeia:

This is the poorest part of the city. A place that is very dangerous to live in and which is dominated by crumbling, poorly maintained, tenement towers. The siege has hit the Oxeia hard, and there are both water and food shortages. The people who live here are poor, but often proud. The Oxeia is dominated by the Prassinoi, a sports team and mafia, that controls much of the city.

The Forum and Hippodromos:

No one lives in these spaces, but everyone goes to them. These monumental gathering places are the central point of the city, and the stage for all the largest rituals of civic life. Festooned with the monuments of centuries of empire, the Forum is an open air museum, and there are disquieting rumors about what happens here at night. The Hippodromos is the place where the chariot races happen. These massive spectacles are rare in this wartime, but they are beloved.

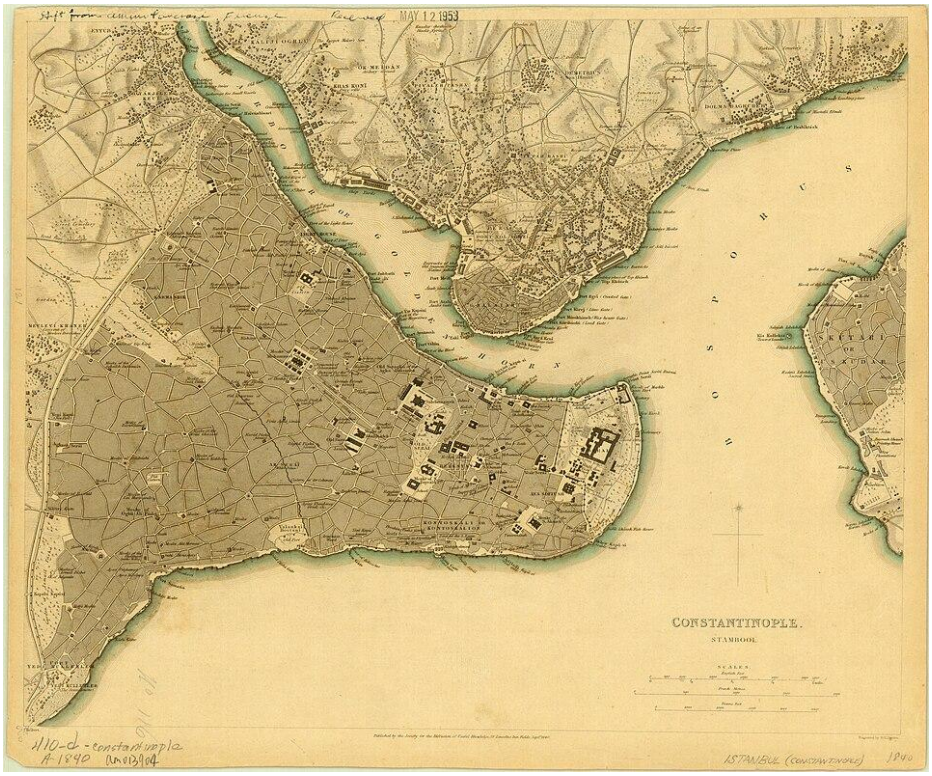


Figure 3 Konstantinoupolis in 1840, B.R. Davies, Wikimedia.

Pre-made characters based on history:

After receiving a ticket, players will give preferences for which of the 40 characters designed for this LARP they wish to play. There will then be pre game workshops to flesh out the characters and the connections between them.

Consent Centred Design:

This LARP functions on a consent centred model for consequences to characters. Only the player can consent to a character death or other severe consequences. Several systems exist for this.

For unplanned escalation:

1. The person to start action decides what kind of action they are taking, and acts accordingly in slow motion. For example, they throw a stage punch slow motion towards someone.
2. The person receiving action decides consequences. For example, the recipient of the punch might put arm up in a block, they might dodge, they might act as if it connected. They then decide what kind of injury (if any) they wish to roleplay.

For planned escalation

1. Players talk to each other ahead of escalation about what terms they are playing on. They then inform a GM. For example: Players might agree to have a full speed knife fight using an honour system, but also set limitations such as explicitly stating that they do not want the scene to end in character death.
2. The actions play out however they do, within terms of player agreement. For example, players play out their knife fight with no certain winner, with a GM present, the person hit then roleplays out the injury in a way that stays within the prearranged limits.

There will also be a variety of safety signs (see forthcoming safety document) that players can use to de-escalate or exit a scene. There will never be IC consequences for OOC needing to leave a scene.

The Siege:

Throughout the game, the GMs will maintain a simulation of the siege. This will be communicated to players by immersive means (letters, messengers, ect). Each player will have ways of affecting the course of the siege via their actions in the game.

Rituals:

Public: All characters will be able to change the course of the city via public rituals. While these include the usual religious rituals, they also include secular group activities such as imperial processions, military parades, or even riots. The larger, cooler, and more immersive the public ritual, the more likely it makes a large impact on setting, for better or worse. A GM must be present for all rituals.

Private: Characters will also have access to private rituals. These represent the more interior aspects of belief. They include private prayer, occult practices, and other forms of private actions. As a rule of thumb, these actions mostly affect the performer and maybe one or two others. But, if conditions are right and actions are cool enough, larger results are possible.

Relics and Occult Objects:

The game includes heavy magical realism elements including the presence of saints and the demonic. There will be tagged objects in the game that are associated with both of these elements and represent objects of power. Control of them will increase potency of all rituals, again for better or worse. They may also attract some surreal plot elements.

Hierarchical Misogyny as a historical system:

This LARP engages with the historical reality that the past social systems were misogynistic by design and that 626 marks a point where the Roman world became distinctly more patriarchal. It asks players to engage carefully and critically with themes of intensely unequal hierarchy and an unstable society that is becoming more misogynistic than it used to be. A goal of the LARP is to invite players to examine both how insidious historical misogynistic ideas could be while also giving players an opportunity to resist the imposition of oppressive ideas.

This said, we will not be representing the historical practice of underage marriages, and all characters are written as if they are at least 18.

Illness and Injury:

Illness and injury are both consequences that can be roleplayed out at player discretion. Several characters within the game will be specialists in healing, either magical or practical. This is a world where death via disease and injury was common and cures are risky, so we encourage RP that reflects that.

Death, Undeath, and Resurrection:

Death is a distinct choice that you can make for your character in this story. When a character dies the player will first have a debrief with one of the GM team. Then they will have some choices. Haunting other characters as a ghost and various types of more physical undeath based on balkan folklore are potential continuations of a characters story. Resurrection is also possible, if certain conditions are met. There will always also be the option of playing a backup character. The conversation with the GM will help debrief about the experience of death and decide which path the player prefers to take.

EduLARP:

The educational aspect of this game is centred before and after the runtime. Before the run, players will have access to workshops and other resources for understanding the history behind their characters. After the game we will hold an epilogue session, in which we will discuss how the story we told together differs from history and reflect on what we learned by this exercise in biofiction.

If you seek a terrifying throne of God on earth,
behold, marvel at the house of the Virgin
for she carrying God with her arms
carries him into the worship of this place.
Here those having been ordained to rule the earth
have faith that they hold the scepter of victory
here many universal misfortunes
The Patriarch keeping vigil averts.
And the Barbarians besieging the city,
As they saw that she alone commanded
they bent straightaway their unbending necks.

Εἰ φρικτὸν ἐν γῇ τοῦ Θεοῦ ζητεῖς θρόνον,
ἰδὼν τὸν οἶκον θαύμασον τῆς παρθένου·
ἡ γὰρ φέρουσα τὸν Θεὸν ταῖς ἀγκάλαις
φέρει τὸν αὐτὸν εἰς τὸ τοῦ τόπου σέβας.
ἐνταῦθα τῆς γῆς οἱ κρατεῖν τεταγμένοι
τὰ σκῆπτρα πιστεύουσι τῆς νίκης ἔχειν·
ἐνταῦθα πολλὰς κοσμικὰς περιστάσεις
ὁ πατριάρχης ἀγρυπνῶν ἀνατρέπει.
οἱ βάρβαροι δὲ προσβαλόντες τῇ πόλει,
αὐτὴν στρατηγήσασαν ὡς εἶδον μόνην,
ἔκαμψαν εὐθὺς τοὺς ἀκαμπεῖς αὐχένας.

Iambic poem by Georgios Pisides, Church Ambassador and Poet, inscribed at the site of the Battle of Blachernae in 626 CE.

Costuming Expectations

We expect all players to make an attempt at costuming, but do not expect full historical accuracy. Simple belted tunics were worn by most of the population in the 7th century, with more elaborate accessories being reserved for the powerful and wealthy. Costumes should attempt to tell the story of the character, so accessories should be picked carefully to actively support the role the character is playing. We will provide more detail on historically accurate costuming for those who wish, but all that is required is a basic attempt.

Basic Tunic: Almost every character regardless of gender would historically have worn a basic tunic as a core garment. The tunics of the Late Antique period were wide and boxy, and often adorned with embroidered stripes. They were made of linen and wool for the most part, with only the extremely wealthy owning silk. Linen underlayers with wool outer tunics is a very good way to costume for this event. We will provide patterns for historical tunics, and acceptable ones are also available via online retailers. Sometimes Indian clothing that looks the part can also be found in Op Shops.

Outer layers: The weather at this event is not expected to be especially warm, so cloaks, outer tunics and other ways of staying in character while remaining warm are highly encouraged for all players. Large wool blankets are a very good stand in for the cloaks used in the period. Avoid Red cloaks, and only use purple cloaks if playing Royalty.

Shoes: Shoes need to allow for traversal of difficult terrain. We would strongly prefer it if people wear plain modern hiking shoes or the like rather than wear period shoes that lack traction.

Accessories: Accessories should tell the story of the character. It makes sense for some characters to flaunt wealth, for others to hide it, and for still others to just not have it. Coin jewellery in particular was common among those who had more wealth. True upper class characters generally display wealth in a tasteful way, while those new to wealth often go to extremes.

Weapons and Armor: Most characters can have a LARP dagger or other working tool. These will be inspected before game on to assess safety. Otherwise, swords and other military weapons should be reserved to characters who have a military role in the game. Armor also is reserved to characters that have a military role within the game or who have clandestine connections allowing access to illegal goods.

Pants: Flamboyant pants are seen as barbaric in the7th century and associated with the Persians and Avars. This does not stop them from being trendy amongst the lower classes.

For the purpose of this game, which is occurring in cold weather, leggings and other modern warmth wear are treated as bare legs, but baggy patterned pants should be only worn if the character wants to make a statement.

Diadems and Purple Mantles: The Imperial family should be the only people wearing diadems/crowns or Tyrian purple mantles. It is possible that some of the more wealthy senatorial families might own such things, but wearing them openly would be a declaration of war.

Greens and Blues: The chariot racing factions in Konstantinoupolis formed a kind of mob that ran much of the city. Wearing Green or Blue could be seen as a statement of support for one of those two mafias and should be done with care.

Red Cloaks: The wandering GMs will be wearing bright red cloaks. So please avoid making cloaks of this colour.



Figure 4 Justinian and his Retinue, 6th Century, Ravenna

Costume Ideas Gallery’

The following pictures of Viv, Joy, and Vasiliki in Costume. They are meant to provide examples of ways to tell a story with costuming. You will notice a lot of repetition of elements throughout these. In the context of this LARP, styling the material to tell a story matters far more than the specific accuracy of any given piece of clothing.



Respectable but poor Woman from Oxeia. Simple linen tunic bought online. Heddle woven belt made by Joy, headscarf bought online.

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Poor, Infamous woman from Oxeia. Same elements as before, but styled less modestly with a dagger (bought from Calimacil) thrown in her belt for protection in the hard streets.



Wealthy infamous actress from Sphorakiou.

Costume uses same linen undertunic belt and knife as before, but then has more layered on. It has a Skirt from an op shop, a Kaftan bought at a medieval fair, a Remo synthetic head tambourine, a silk coin pouch made by Joy, and a set of coin jewellery found at an op shop.

Kaftans in particular are seen as exotic in this era.



Respectable upper class woman from Sphorakiou. Same underlayers as before, with the addition of a boldly coloured linen tunic (made by Joy) and a headscarf for modesty.



Extremely rich woman from the Palace or Sphorakiou. Same underlayers as before, but the addition of pearl earrings and a red and purple silk coat with pearl beading take the outfit from expensive to almost imperial. Depending on attitude, this could be a high class courtesan or an imperial princess who is not wearing her regalia. A diadem or a purple mantle would take this from almost imperial to outright royalty.



Rich Monastic Abbess from the Great Church. Same underlayers as before, but with several more headscarves, one of a nice silk brocade that was found in an op shop. She holds a reliquary box (a jewellery box found in an op shop.)



Masculine leaning infamous street tough from Oxeia. Simple linen tunic, Cali knife, belt from Armstreet, pants found in an op shop, jewellery found in op shop, hat bought at medieval fair. The green belt indicates allegiance to the Prassinoi (Green) mob. This character is dressing edgily and is being very provocative.



Foreign Soldier from the Mangana. This character wears a (upholstery fabric) brocade tunic made by joy, a long kaftan found at a medieval fair, and baggy pants found at an op shop. Fake Steel Kilij is later period, but has a similar profile to Hunnic swords of the Late Antique period. They are coded as extremely foreign, perhaps one of the mercenaries brought in from abroad to defend the city.



Masculine leaning well off middle class individual from Oxeia or Sphorakiou. Simple clothing, but in bold and expensive colours, with a very nice coin purse. Undertunic bought online, homemade belt, coin purse, and simple tunic.



Masculine Street Tough from Sphorakiou. Same layers as before, but with added coin jewellery, a knife from Cali, and an arm band indicating allegiance to a sports team.



Roman Soldier from the Mangana. Roman styled LARP weapons from Calimacil. Simple round shield with gold marker Personalisation from Epic Armory. Lamellar laced together by Joy. Otherwise same undertunics as before.



Priestly Vestments for a practicing priest of the Great Church. Homemade dalmatic made from upholstery fabric brocade. Stole adapted from a scarf. Icon found at an op shop.



Moderately wealthy working class masculine figure from Oxeia. Yellow tunic is an indian tunic found at a local op shop.



Imperial Regalia from Palace. Cloak found at an art fair, headpiece from a Turkish shop, homemade brocade dalmatic. Metal headdresses and purple cloaks indicate extreme royalty and should be worn with care.

Character List Introduction

Gender and Infamy

In the *Miracles of 626* we will be avoiding a simple binary gender system in favor of a variety of different types of gendered labels based on historical concepts from the time period. Each of the characters has a gender, or choice of genders assigned to them. Due to historical misogyny and lack of source material, more characters are masculine than feminine. That said, in all cases it is possible to play the character as secretly having a different identity. **We highly encourage you to reach out to the game runners if you wish to play any of these characters as secretly having a different gender**.

Rather than a binary system, the Medieval Roman world believed that sex was more of a continuum, in which masculine and feminine were two opposite poles of a singular human existence. As such, the identity labels we are using for *Miracles of 626* are more transient than our modern conceptions, and changed with changes of status, respectability, and age.

The roman world was also split into two categories of people, those who were considered respectable and those who fell under the legal category of infamy. Each profession was categorized according to law, and those which were lower class were generally seen as infamy while those of higher status were respectable. For feminine identities in particular, this distinction was life changing, as respectability is tied closely into feminine identity within the patriarchal structure.

Infamous, Royalty, Respectable, Clergy, Military:

Each character is classed into one of the categories above. Infamous characters are those who have a conflicted relationship with the law. Respectable characters are generally understood to be upstanding citizens. Clergy are openly members of the church and make up their own class of people. Military figures are allowed to wear weapons and armour and control aspects of the military situation. Royalty are the absolute pinnacle of the social class and operate under heavy social constraints.

Explanation of Gender titles, from most feminine to most masculine

Gyne [gy-NEE] (Adult Respectable Feminine Role) (She/Her)

The label of gyne is a feminine gender title associated with respectable motherhood and with being a wife. It is one of the most constrained genders in 7th century society, with high social expectations of dignity and restraint. Motherhood within marriage is pedestalized as an ideal and honorable way of life, but also these women are legally prohibited from power so long as they stay married. Widows were still considered gyne, but were less constrained by masculine authority.

Parthenos [Par-THIN-os] (Unmarried Respectable Feminine Role) (She/Her)

The Parthenos is a highly respectable feminine identity associated with feminine figures who have come of age but have not married. While it is usually translated as Virgin, it is a status that is more connected to the institution of Marriage than it is any physical experiences. In most cases, this is a very short-lived status, a Parthenos is expected to quickly marry, and when she does not she can quickly lose her status as a respectable figure. The main exception to this is nuns, who live entire lives in this status and are highly regarded.

Mima [MI-ma] (Infamous Feminine Leaning Non-binary Role) (She/They)

Mima, which literally means actress, is one of many labels used for feminine figures who were associated with the legal status of infamy, which generally just meant that they had a public facing role. While they were feminized and highly sexualized, they were portrayed as deviant and less pure than other kinds of feminine people and were often associated with more masculine behaviors. Most of the hospitality, acting, sex work, and culture roles within the urban landscape were held by people of this identity. While they face legal and church persecution, they have a great deal more freedom than any other feminine identity and have in the past gained incredible power.

Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (He/They) (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

The evnoukhos is a masculine identity that is associated with those who cannot grow beards. The label covers both trans-masculine figures who chose to become more masculine and others who were made into evnoukhoi by surgical means. In both cases, the transition was often, but not always, a decision made by parents or guardians when the evnoukhos was a child. They hold a special power within the palace, where they are trusted to handle the most sensitive issues of government. They also hold special authority in the church, which highly prizes chastity.

Ephevos [EF-ee-vos] (Unmarried Masculine Role)

The Ephevos was a young masculine identity associated with the period of time in which a young masculine person was not fully able to grow a beard. This status tended to last longer than it's feminine equivalent, and ephevoi were expected to be a bit on the wild side. The status ends either when the ephevos marries or when they fully grow a beard. If neither happens, they will eventually be recategorized as evnoukhos.

Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Highly Masculine Role)

The anēr is a masculine identity that sits at the very top of the patriarchal social structure. Defined as a person able to grow a full beard, the Roman legal system actively is built around the assumption that almost all major leadership roles are held by people of this identity. The role requires the performance of strength and power, usually at the expense of others. While it is highly associated with fatherhood, it is not uncommon for an anēr to be unmarried, especially if they are younger.

The Factions

Factions in Miracles of 626 are less coherent organizational structures than they are a reflection of what part of the city your character sleeps in. Each of the five categories represent specific living arrangements, ranging from the palace to the slums of the city. They represent networks of association, but loyalties within the setting are highly personal.

Pronunciation

Each name and role has a pronunciation guide associated with it. Each syllable gets the same amount of time, and the capitalized syllable is where the stress of the word falls. We offer these as a way of helping set the scene to make it easier to stay within a 7th century mindset. The attempt is far more important than consistently getting it right!

Because the alphabet in use was the Greek alphabet, there are a few places where a pronunciation distinction is made with bolded letters:

th=a soft th sound, like in both

th=a hard th sound, like in the

y= a ya sound, slightly guttural.

The Great Church:

The Great Church of Hagia Sophia [ha-YEE-a Soph-EE-a] and the Patriarchal Palace occupy a good chunk of the urban landscape of the oldest part of Konstantinoupolis. They are well supplied with food and water, and live in luxury only surpassed by the inhabitants of the great palace. The patriarchal palace also hosts the largest library of the city, a collection of texts that date back centuries.

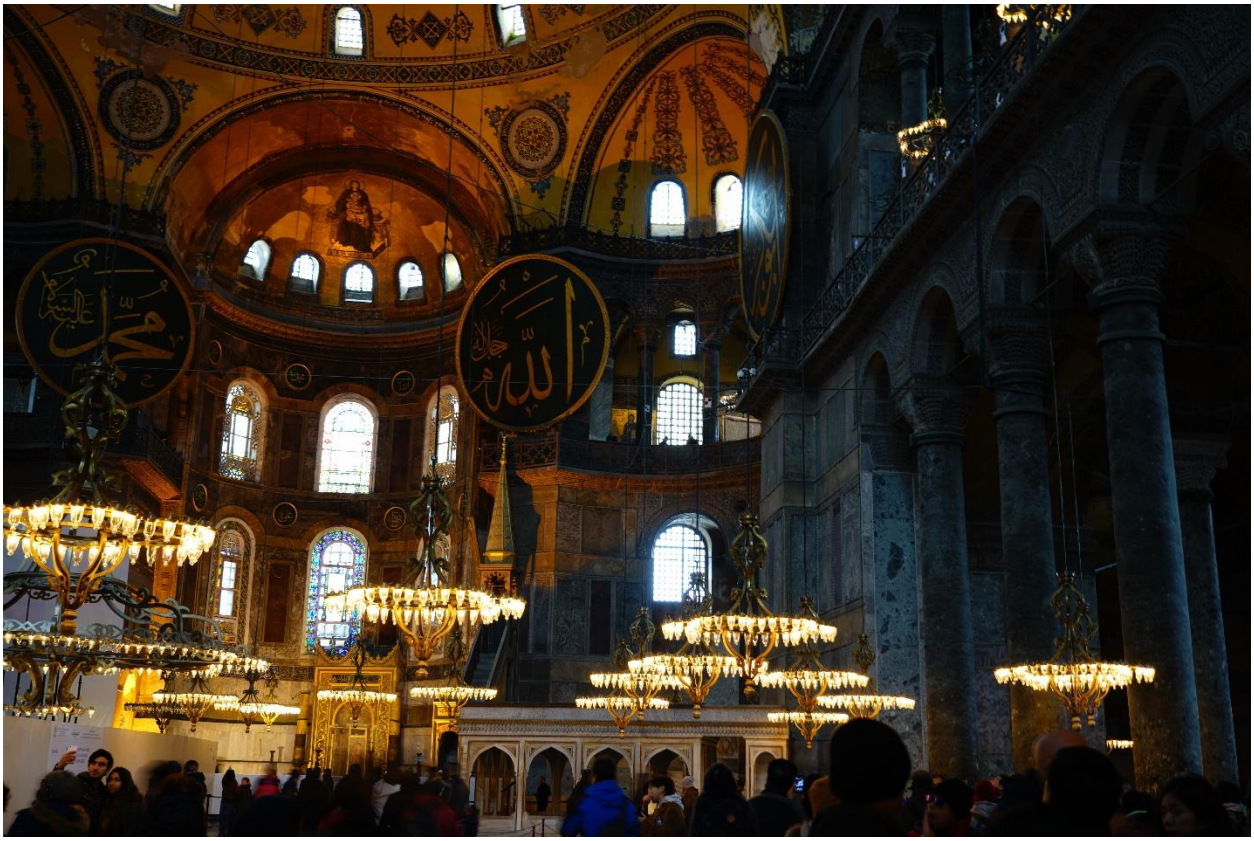


Figure 5 Interior of Hagia Sophia. Wikimedia

Sergios [SER-yee-os]

Role: Patriarchēs [pa-tree-ÁR-chis] (Patriarch) of the Church

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Clergy

Literacy: Accomplished. A patron of the arts, if not an artistic writer himself.

Description: Sergios is an elderly churchman who fancies himself the leader not only of the church of Konstantinoupolis, but of the entire Christian world. He has used the absence of the Vasileus [Vas-il-EFS] (Emperor) to bolster church authority and wants nothing more than to create a new theocratic empire. He is directly at odds with the Vasilissa [Vas-il-IS-sa] (Empress) and is quite misogynistic.

Over the last decades he has built a stable of learned supporters to support his attempts to reform church and empire. As the sole patron of the arts in these dark times, his supporters include poets, historians, philosophers, and religious leaders. Despite his ambition, he has little hard power, but wields a great deal of spiritual and moral authority.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a charismatic villain who is likely to die or be run out of town in a dramatic fashion
- To play a character with a great deal of authority, but little physical power, who has to use words and wealth to get what he wants in the world.
- To be a visible symbol of religious authority.
- To lead a wide variety of religious rituals.
- To often be the centre of attention, for better or worse.
- Play a character with a highly detailed backstory and connections and whose actions are quite constrained by social expectations.

Theodōros Synkellos [the-OH-**th**oor-os]

Role: Companion to Patriarchēs, Diplomat, and Sermon giver.

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Clergy

Literacy: Prodigy, reads in several languages.

Description: Theodoros is a high-ranking clergyman who has risen through the ranks of the church to be next in line to the Patriarch Sergios. He is an accomplished speechwriter, who has done a great deal of work to bolster his patron's theocratic agenda. He is also the designated patriarchal diplomat and keeps being thrown into quite dangerous negotiations as a result. Publicly, Theodoros backs Sergios in everything he does and is Sergios's most stalwart ally, but does his public conviction and sermons match his actual beliefs?

For Theodoros the siege is both an opportunity and a danger. The opportunity is that the power vacuum allows for advancement both of Sergios's agenda for the church and potentially of Theodoros's own position in the church. However, Theodoros's role as a diplomat means that he is likely to end up in difficult situations that he needs to use his silver tongue to talk his way out of. If he can successfully choose the right words, there is no limit to what he might achieve.

Choose this character if you want:

- To be an important religious leader, but not the head of the church (yet)
- To use words to get what you want and negotiate your way through dangerous diplomatic exchanges.
- To be involved, but not necessarily at the center of, a wide variety of religious ritual.
- To be a symbol of religious authority.
- To play a character with a highly detailed backstory and wide-ranging connections, but who has fewer limits and constraints than the Patriarchēs.

Geōrgios Pisidēs [yee-ORG-i-os pi-SI-**th**ees]

Role: Patriarchal Diplomat to the Palace, Poet.

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Clergy

Literacy: The best writer in the city.

Description: Twenty years ago, Geōrgios Pisidēs was the best poet in the city of Pisidia, winning all the local competitions and acing every exam. This regional success brought him to the capital of the city, where his talents were recognized by the newly elevated Patriarches Sergios. He has spent the last decades in a church supported position where his job has been to write poetry that flatters the imperial court and makes Sergios's agenda more palatable to the elites of the city. The power vacuum of Herakleios's absence has changed things, however, and the church sees an opportunity to use Georgios's talents to directly bolster the Patriarches, rather than the various imperial dynasts.

In the context of the siege, Georgios is well connected in the palace and the church, with each member of the Heraklian family believing that he is on their side and will write poetry in their honour. This is an incredible opportunity for the mid-career poet, as he is likely to receive many commissions and rise within both the church and the palace. It is also dangerous, as flattering the wrong person can lead to disaster in the tumultuous environment of the City.

Choose this character if you want:

- To be the most important (or rather, only) poetic writer of the age.
- To seek out and record the stories of other characters.
- To look for opportunities to perform poetry.
- To be involved in a variety of diplomatic engagements between palace and the church.
- To chart a path with pretty words through the power vacuum and commemorate the siege.
- To play a character with a highly detailed backstory and connections, but who is otherwise mostly unconstrained in their actions.

Theophylaktos Simokattēs [the-oh-FYL-ak-tos si-moh-KAT-tees]

Role: Lawyer, Historian, Philosopher

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Clergy

Literacy: Prodigy, reads in several languages.

Description: Theophylaktos is a master of many trades. He is the only active historian and philosopher remaining in the city of Konstantinoupolis as well as being a legal professional and teacher of law courses. He was born in Egypt, but has spent the last decade on Sergios's retainer. His role within the city is to research and record history, continue the traditions of philosophy, and occasionally to win a legal case for either the church or one of the aristocratic families.

In this siege, Theophylaktos finds himself somewhat at loose ends. Certainly, Sergios will reward him if he is able to tell the story of the siege in a favorable light for the Patriarch, but perhaps it is time to seek a new patron. Perhaps someone exists who is willing to support the philosophical and historical arts without requiring the past to be changed to suit the present need?

Choose this character if you want:

- To be the most important (or rather, only) historian and philosopher of the age.
- To actively seek out and record the stories of other characters
  To seek out opportunities to tell other characters about history
- To be involved in potential legal proceedings, should they occur.
- To chart a path with pretty words through the power vacuum and commemorate the siege.
- To play a character with a highly detailed backstory and connections, but who is otherwise mostly unconstrained in their actions.

Anastasia [An-as-tas-EE-a]

Role: Gerondissa [Yer-ON-di-sa] (Abbess)

Gender: Parthenos [Par-THIN-os] (Unmarried Respectable Feminine Role)

Clergy

Literacy: An accomplished letter writer, Anastasia corresponds with most of the upper class of the empire and is known for sharply worded commentary.

Description: Anastasia has been running a women's monastic establishment, the Monastery of the Panaghia Hodegetria [Pan-agh-EE-a Ode-e-yet-RI-a] for decades. She comes from the bluest of blue blood families, and within her small, cloistered domain has absolute power and authority. The siege has caused her to leave the monastery, escorting an important relic of the Theotokos to wherever it is needed.

She is alarmed by what she sees outside of her cloister. While she cares deeply for her church and city, she is also deeply skeptical of the new religious practices put in place by the Patriarchēs, and finds his claims to the power of the Theotokos to be actively offensive. She is openly dismissive of the Heraklian dynasts as well, seeing them as usurpers and upstarts to the empire that her family once ruled. Anastasia has kept herself restrained for decades, limiting herself to an occasional letter, perhaps now is the time to make some noise?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a self-assured holy woman who believes she understands the divine will better than anyone
- To engage with the supernatural and be involved with 'miracles'
- To be a voice of resistance to both Church and Palace, and potentially end up a martyr.
- To engage with deep personal piety and devotion
- To play a character who is unconstrained by tradition or social standing.

Symeon [Sim-EE-on]

Role: Holy Fool and Wonder Worker

Gender: Agender

Infamous, secretly Clergy

Literacy: Hidden. Can read well but pretends not to.

Description: Symeon used to be a normal monk, just wandering the landscape of Palestine and neglecting his body as he prayed. That was before they were touched by something supernatural. Now they have become something much more flamboyant. They wandered into town a few years ago, dragging a dead animal behind them, and very quickly became known for wild slapstick nonsense. They play jokes on people, dance without shame, and do not pay any heed to social standing or tradition. It is only in retrospect that people realize that Symeon's antics have a message and that the world is calmer after their chaos than it was before they came.

The siege is for Symeon nothing worth worrying about. What matters to them is that people treat each other with kindness and that the world returns to a balance which it has lost in this time of endless war. They have started getting just enough of a reputation that people are starting to wonder what exactly is going on with his supernatural antics, but only one other person knows the full story. Will they successfully make a better world around them, or will they end up a martyr and scapegoat for the stresses of the siege?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play someone completely out of touch with concerns of the world
- To engage with the supernatural and be involved with 'miracles'
- To seem like just a strange little guy but do so in a way that hides moral messages.
- To be a voice of resistance to both Church and Palace and potentially end up a martyr.
- To engage with deep personal piety and devotion.
- To play a character who is unconstrained by tradition or social standing.

Eleusios, [el-ef-SI-os]

Role: former Episkopos [ep-IS-koh-pos] (Bishop) of Anastasioupolis [An-ast-as-ee-OU-po-lis] and famous monk.

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Formerly Infamous, now Clergy

Literacy: Delusional. He certainly writes a lot, and thinks he is a good reader and writer, but it's mostly quotes from sermons taken out of context and his reading comprehension is often low.

Description: Eleusios is a very old, very angry, monk who seems to delight in nothing more than telling people what exactly they have done to displease God. He is from the countryside and was born into a family associated with innkeeping and sex work. As a youth, he manipulated, connived against, and abused the women around him into giving up their trade and supporting his religious aspirations. He was the Episkopos of a local city for a grand total of six months, before he angrily stormed out of the city and resigned. Since then, he has been a wandering ascetic monk who berates anyone and everyone. He claims that St. Georgios [yee-ORG-i-os] protects him and allows him to command demons, but there's no one alive who has ever seen proof of this.

Eleusios is in the city because the Sasanians have overrun the part of Anatolia that he comes from. Rather than seek aid in a genteel way, he has been busy radicalizing everyone around him and preaching the coming apocalypse. He thinks the Heraklian dynasty is a bunch of incestuous sinners, that Sergios's new religious ideas have destroyed the religion, that the people of the city are all corrupted by their love of theatre and chariot races, and believes that anyone who takes a bath opens their soul up for corruption.

Choose this character if you want:

- To be an absolute monumental pain in the arse to absolutely everyone around you.
- Possibly get yourself killed or run out of town in a dramatic fashion.
- Wrestle with internalized self-hate that has turned outwards.
- Play with ascetic religious imagery and wear clothing that has seen better years.
- Get up on a soapbox and declare that the end times are near.
- Attempt exorcisms and engage with the demonic, knowing that you will fail.

The Great Palace:

The most luxurious part of the city is the sprawling great palace. It is a complex full of ceremonial halls, ballrooms, gardens, baths, private chapels, and private libraries. The imperial elite and those who guard and care for them live here, cloistered from the rest of the city. The main contact that the imperial inhabitants have with their subjects is in the context of imperial processions and from the imperial box in the hippodrome [hip-po-THRO-mee. Th here is hard, like in the.], a giant chariot racing arena that is attached to the palace by a secret tunnel.



Figure 6 Mosaic Floor from the Great Palace of Konstantinoupolis

Martina [mar-TIN-a]

Role: Vasilissa [vas-il-IS-sa] (Empress)

Gender: Gyne [gy-NEE] (Adult Respectable Feminine Role)

Royalty

Literacy: Functional, but not something she practices often.

Martina is the young wife of the absent Herakleios [Her-ak-LEE-os], who is also her uncle. She has very little direct authority of her own, but anyone who offends her must answer to her uncles, both of whom are leading armies in the east. Her life is filled with pomp and circumstance, and incredible luxury, but the situation in the palace is getting dangerous.

She has two young children, but neither is the heir to the throne, that position goes to Konstantinos [kon-sta-DIN-os], her stepson who has only recently come of age. The Church has actively declared her an enemy and refused to sanction her wedding or children, and they have been seen talking to her stepchildren. Who will protect her during this siege… or will she find a way to protect herself?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a high-risk game of courtly intrigue in which character death is a distinct possibility.
- Use wealth, connections, and charisma to try and survive.
- Play a character who is the centre of attention in every space she occupies.
- Play a character who leads political processions.
- Play a young woman trapped in a quite scary political environment.
- To play a character with highly detailed connections and backstory, but whose social actions are highly constrained by tradition and expectations.
- To wear purple.

Konstantinos [kon-sta-DIN-os]

Role: Junior Vasileus [Vas-il-EFS] (Emperor)

Gender: Ephevos [EF-ee-vos] (Unmarried Masculine Role)

Royalty

Literacy: Has been taught how to read but hates it.

Konstantinos is Herakleios's second born child and heir to the throne. He is a young man who has just come of age, trapped in an echo chamber of self-serving whispers that seek to mold him to the agenda of others. His mother died when he was too young to remember her, leaving him and his older sister to be raised by court officials. His father is a distant, absent, figure who has spent more time on campaign than the palace, and is a larger than life military figure who everyone keeps comparing him unfavourably to. Life can be hard, even when you are the richest young man in the world.

The siege is both an opportunity and a risk. The opportunity is that Konstantinos can live up to his family reputation, and prove a decisive leader in a time of war. But the power vacuum is a threat. People around him keep telling Konstantinos that his step-mother and cousin, Martina, who is only a year or two older than he is, is a threat to his position and life. The Patriarches Sergios has been visiting him constantly, telling him stories of past kings who listened to their religious leaders. Who will this young man become?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a high-risk game of courtly intrigue in which character death is a distinct possibility.
- Use wealth, connections, and charisma to try and survive.
- Play a character who is the center of attention in every space he occupies
- Play a character who leads political processions.
- To play a young man who has barely started figuring himself out.
- To play a character with highly detailed connections and backstory, but whose social actions are highly constrained by tradition and expectations.
- To wear purple.

Epiphania [ep-ee-phan-EE-a]

Role: Porphyrogenitē Vasilissa [por-phir-rho-YEN-it-a vas-il-IS-sa] (Empress Born into the Purple)

Gender: Parthenos [Par-THIN-os] (Unmarried Respectable Feminine Role)

Royalty

Literacy: Spectacular, but her skill with words is hidden from most others.

Description: Epiphania is the firstborn child of Herakleios. She was born soon after the bloody coup that brought the Emperor into power. She has been on display as a member of the imperial dynasty for her entire life, but her gender prevents her from being considered for any active governance role. As far as everyone around her is concerned, her main role in life is to eventually make a political marriage, but even this seems unlikely to occur. The generals and senators that married imperial women with Porphyrogenitē status in the past went on to lead coups of their own!

However, Epiphania is an extremely competent woman and has her own plans for the world. She may be trapped within the palace culture, but she has read almost every book in the library and maintains a lively correspondence with the family of her mother. She approaches everything she does with a singular perfectionism, and there are whispers that she might be preparing to take her destiny into her own hands.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a high-risk game of courtly intrigue in which character death is a distinct possibility.
- Use wealth, connections, and charisma to try and survive.
- Play a character who is the centre of attention in every space she occupies
- Play a character who leads political processions.
- To play a young woman who has turned to perfectionism as a way of surviving in the palace environment.
- To play a character with highly detailed connections and backstory, but whose social actions are highly constrained by tradition and expectations.
- To wear purple.

Niketas [Nik-EE-tas]

Role: Komes tōn Exkouvitōn [KOM-ees tone ex-KOO-vit-on] (Commander of the Chamber-Guards)

Gender: Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Military

Literacy: Competent. Has a soft spot for ancient Greek poetry.

Description: Niketas has been a fixture of the palace culture since Herakleios came into power. His official position is as the leader of one of the three units of palace guards. He is charged with the protection of the domestic spaces within the palace, and as such has developed a role as spy master and protector for the imperial women. He is good at his job and has served faithfully throughout his career. While he tries to be impartial, he is particularly fond of Epiphania and has spent a good deal of free time discussing literature with the young princess.

Things have become challenging in the emperor's absence, however. The supplies for the city are not sufficient, and Niketas has recently gotten in trouble for prioritizing the palace over other parts of the city. Just a few weeks before the siege, his rivals in the palace worked with the Patriarches Sergios to deny food to Niketas's guardsmen. This has left him resentful and angry. The power vacuum in the palace is also dangerous. As an evnoukhos, Niketas is barred from holding power himself, but in the past people in his position have become kingmakers.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play an armed and armoured character with a moderate chance of ending up in a situation involving deadly violence.
- To play spymaster and potential kingmaker in a deadly game of palace politics.
- To play a character who has a complex gender and a role in the world defined by their non-binary identity
- To play a warrior-poet.
- To play a character with moderately detailed connections and backstory, but whose social actions are highly constrained by tradition and expectations.

Alexandros [Al-eks-AN-**th**ros]

Role: Eparchos tōn Praitoriōn [EP-arch-os ton Pray-TOR-ee-on] (Praetorian Prefect)

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Military

Literacy: Functional but mostly used for practical purposes.

Description: As the leader of the Praetorians, Alexandros is in charge of the oldest palace guard unit in the city, but they are a military unit in name only. The praetorians are no longer the closest guards of the ruling class but instead are tasked with the urban security of the palace within the city and generally are too diffused throughout the city to be useful in a crisis. Instead, Alexandros's days are filled with paperwork. He oversees the distribution of food, serves as the supreme judge of the city, and generally is held responsible for any riots or calamities within the city.

The siege has been an extremely difficult time for him. First the food ships out of Egypt stopped, then the Avars cut the main aqueduct into the city, and now he has to feed ten thousand hungry soldiers on top of the normal administrative burden of running the world's largest city. As such, he is stressed, and his decisions have started making him a large number of enemies.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play an old soldier with a demanding desk job
- To be tasked with resolving disputes between characters
- To play a deeply stressed out professional quartermaster
- To deal with problems for which there are no good solutions
- To wear weapons and armour but be reluctant to use them.
- To play a character with moderately detailed connections and backstory, but whose social actions are highly constrained by tradition and expectations.

Leontios [lee-OND-ee-os.]

Role: Komēs tōn Spathariōn [KOM-ees ton spath-ar-EE-on. Th here is as in the] (Commander of the Swordbearers)

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Military

Literacy: Limited. Can read military reports, that is about it.

Description: Leontios is a very hard man who has seen a great deal of violence in his life. A loyalist of Herakleios, he accompanied the ruler on several campaigns in prior years before taking an injury which removed him from the front lines. His reward was the position of commander of the swordbearers, a unit of palace guards who are tasked with accompanying the rulers any time that they leave the palace. This role has made him into a mentor and role model for the young Konstantinos, as well as a close personal bodyguard.

As the siege has settled in, Leontios has become very aware of the risk of attempts on the life of his charge. He sees threats everywhere, barbarian spies, potential revolutionaries, disgruntled senators, ambitious military men, sycophantic clerics, and especially the other members of the royal family all seem like dangerous threats to his charge. How far will this loyal guard go to make sure his charge survives?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a vigilant bodyguard with his head on a swivel.
- To play with the consequences of an old injury
- To engage with palace politics and potentially become a kingmaker
- To play as a mentor, protector, and advocate for a younger character
- To play a character with moderately detailed connections and backstory, but whose social actions are highly constrained by tradition and expectations.

Rhētorios [rhee-TOR-ee-os]

Role: Astrologer

Gender: Any.

Infamous

Literacy: Exceptional. Reads a wide variety of dead languages, and has invented a few constructed languages of his own.

Description: Rhētorios is the last of a long line of magical practitioners and astrologers who trace their lineage back to the Pharonic period in Egypt. They are a master of the techniques of astrology and magic, as well as alchemical arts and more practical spells. They have spent the last decades travelling the world, seeking new magical abilities and practical skills. Recently, Herakleios invited him to the Palace to oversee Martina's pregnancies.

In the siege the skills of an astrologer are in high demand, but so is the risk of censure. People come to Rhētorios when they are uncertain of the future and when they need alchemical cures. They also, a bit more secretly, come to him when they want illegal magics and poisons. He is also the sole remaining open practitioner of Hellenic religion in the city and has ambition to revive the old religion. If his skills don't get him into trouble, the siege offers an opportunity to show the power of the old gods.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play with ancient ideas of magic and alchemy
- To play an esoteric old scholar who drops names like Hermes Trismegistus, Vettius Valens, and Antiochus of Athens without realizing that no one else has ever heard of any of them.
- To get involved in dark rituals and clandestine religious meetings
- For there to be a high chance of your character being targeted by the church, with potentially deadly consequence.
- To play a character whose prior connections are open to development by player and who is generally free from normal social constraints.

Narses [nar-SEES]

Role: Papias [pap-EE-as] (‘father’, head of the Palace servants).

Gender: Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Respectable

Literacy: Highly literate, can carry effective conversations about philosophy.

Description: Narses was sold into palace service as a young child by his destitute parents. He has spent an entire life in service there and has watched one dynast after another succumb to the instability of the Roman world. A master of seeming to be on everyones side, he has successfully kept himself from being a victim of any of the many purges that have torn through the palace in the last three decades.

Now, however, he has, through the simple act of surviving, found himself in charge of the security and wellbeing of the entire palace. He is terrified by having been placed in this role, for he knows he will not survive the next purge, if it happens. As such, the siege seems far away, but the power vacuum in the palace is utterly terrifying. What will he do to secure his future?
Choose this character if you want:

- To play an old palace servant caught in a dangerous position.
- To use wealth, connections, and charisma to try and survive.
- To engage with themes of being a victim of enforced servitude.
- To play a character who has a complex gender and a role in the world defined by their non-binary identity
- To play a character whose backstory and connections are open to player development, but whose position in the world is highly constrained by social expectations.

The Mangana [man-YAN-a]

The city armory is positioned between the great church and the great palace. From a makeshift encampment around the armory, the military elite plan their defence of the city.



Figure 7 Ruins of the Mangana Complex. Picture by Springer Nature.

Bonos [BON-os]

Role: Archistrategos [Arch-EE-strat-EE-yos] (Commander in Chief)

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Military

Literacy: Competent but uninspired. Finds poetry insipid.

Bonos is an elderly soldier who was hand picked by Herakleios's father to help him launch a bloody coup decades before. One of the few people that Herakleios trusts, Bonos has been left in charge of the defense of the city and has been working tirelessly to make sure that the city survives. He has played a neutral role in civic politics but has lost track of the many internal threats as he focuses on the practical matter of winning a battle.

Unfortunately, Bonos's health is worse than he pretends. He gives off the impression of a hearty vigor, riding all over the city and bolstering troops wherever he goes, but his heart is no longer what it was and the stress of the war has been causing more and more signs of a serious health problem. Will he accomplish his goals before his ailing body fails him?

Choose this Character if you want:

- To be at the center of the military planning aspect of the game.
- To play a strong-willed old soldier with lots of war stories to tell.
- To wrestle with poor health and its consequences and have opportunities to die of old age in a dramatic fashion.
- To be politically neutral, even when you really should take a side.
- To play a character with moderately detailed connections and backstory, but whose social actions are highly constrained by tradition and expectations.
- To wear armor.

Vardan [VAR-**th**an]

Role: Strategos tēs pēgē [strat-EE-yos tis pee-YEES] (General of the Fountain)

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Military

Literacy: Cannot read Roman, but can read Armenian and Persian.

Description: Vardan is a military aristocrat from an illustrious Armenian family. As a result of a diplomatic exchange, his family gave him to the Romans to serve as a soldier, and he has spent his entire life fighting on the other side of the empire from his homeland. An accomplished horseman, this siege is the first time in his life where he has spent a great deal of time in the City. In this siege, he is in command of the western side of the defensive wall, centered on the church of the Theotokos [the-oh-TOK-os. Th is soft, as in Theodore] (Mother of God/Virgin Maria) of the Fountain, a site associated with divine miracles.

As a non-Roman forced into roman military service, Vardan finds himself somewhat torn by the job of defending the city. His cultural norms are far closer to those of the Persian army across the Bosporos than they are to the Romans, though there is a long violent history of conflict between his ancestors and the Sasanian rulers. Religiously, he is a devout Christian, but he finds Sergios's changes to the faith to be utter heresy. Yet, despite this discomfort with serving Rome, he has grown fond of the poorer inhabitants of the city and their lifestyles, and has become an avid supporter of the Greens when the chariot races are running. He also despises the Avars and does not wish them to take the city. Where will these torn loyalties lead this soldier?

Choose this character if you want:

- To be involved heavily in the military planning aspect of the game.
- To play a strong-willed soldier with lots of war stories to tell.
- To wrestle with questions of identity and heresy.
- To be an ethnic outsider tasked with the defense of an empire that oppresses your people.
- To play a character with a great deal of flexibility when it comes to connections and backstory, but whose social actions are highly constrained by tradition and expectations.
- To wear armor and be involved in potentially violent scenes.
- To be originally from a culture that expects disagreements to be handled with duels.

Himerios [him-ERR-ee-os]

Role: stratēgos tōn karabōn [strat-EE-yos ton kar-av-ON] (general of ships)

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Military

Literacy: Is only passably literate in Greek, but reads latin well.

Description: Himeros is a career sailor from North Africa who has been involved in a wide variety of naval engagements over the years. He was with Herakleios on his naval expedition to take Konstantinoupolis two decades before. Now a middle aged naval commander, he is in charge of making sure that the seas around Konstantinoupolis remain secure.

He is under a great deal of pressure to get this right. If he makes a mistake the Persians could cross and reinforce the Avars or the Sclavenes could find a way to launch a naval attack against the weakest parts of the city defenses. He both has the most freedom of movement and the least pre-established connections of any of the military men.

Choose this character if you want:

- To be heavily involved in the military planning aspect of the game.
- To play an experienced sailor from the other side of the empire.
- To tell stories of piracy and adventure.
- To play an outsider with few pre-existing connections outside of the military.
- To play a character whose backstory and connections can be heavily player defined, but whose social role and expectations are quite constrained.
- To wear armor and weapons and potentially be directly involved in violent scenes.
- To be originally from a culture that expects disagreements to be handled with duels.

Andronikos [An**th**-RHO-neek-os.]

Role: Strategos tēs Vlakhernēs [strat-EE-yos tis Vlakh-er-NEES](General of the Vlachernae)

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Military

Literacy: Highly competent. Reads Homeric Epics for fun.

Description: Andronikos is the eldest son of an extremely rich senatorial family. His family has realized that their old ancestral rank and power means nothing in the empire of Herakleios and as a result has started trying to gain real military capability. The family's power is based in the east, in the regions that have been overrun by the Persians, and as a result Andronikos has found himself cut off from contact with his family. He is a stoic man, who focuses heavily on maintaining physical fitness, combat capability, and military planning. A voracious reader, he has read every military manual and epic he could acquire.

When it became clear that Konstantinoupolis would come under attack, Herakleios's brother Theodoros sent Andronikos as commander of a unit of heavy cavalry to bolster the city defenses. An arrogant man, Andronikos expected to be in charge of the defense, but has accepted his role as commander of the eastern walls. The church of the Theotokos at Vlachernae falls in the center of his defensive perimeter and looks likely to become a major flashpoint, if he can win the battle there, perhaps he can reinvigorate his family fortunes and maybe even change the trajectory of the Empire.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play an upper-class career soldier raised on stories of past glory
- To be heavily involved in the military planning side of the game
- To play a strong willed and ambitious soldier
- To potentially become involved in palace politics and attempt to advance in status.
- To play a character with a great deal of flexibility when it comes to backstory and prior connections, but whose social actions are highly constrained by tradition and expectations.
- To wear armor and be involved in potentially violent scenes.

Alexios [al-EX-ee-os]

Role: stratēgos tōn karabōn [strat-EE-yos ton kar-av-ON] (general of ships)

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role). Secretly identifies as Gyne [gy-NEE] (Adult Respectable Feminine Role)

Military

Literacy: Competent, but rudimentary.

Description: Alexios is a hardened sailor who has seen a great deal in their life. They have spent the last decade running a desperately underfunded anti-piracy campaign, with limited success. A soldier without strong connections, they have risen to their current rank by pure competence and stubbornness. They also have a secret, namely that they had a different life once, in which they publicly identified as a different gender. After the traumatic destruction of their village, they found themselves first dressing in masculine clothing for safety, and then kept up their disguise for more than a decade, until they effectively became the hardened soldier they are today.

The siege has resulted in a surprising promotion. As one of the only commanders to have any success with countering the Sclavene pirate raids, Bonos recalled Alexios from their command and gave them the new job of helping defend the city. They have a great deal of experience with fighting against Sclavene naval escapades, but will their fellow commanders listen to their hard earned experience?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a hardened soldier from a poor background who is used to being underestimated.
- To be heavily involved in the military simulation part of the game.
- To potentially be involved in armed and violent scenes.
- To engage with complex gender roles in which your own identity and external presentation are different from each other.
- To wear weapons and armor.
- To play a character whose backstory, connections, and social position are heavily open to player interpretation.

Ta Sphorakiou [ta sfor-ak-EE-oo]

Ta Sphorakiou is a neighbourhood in the richest part of the city of Konstantinoupolis. This is a place where the children of former imperial families, the senatorial families, the richest merchants, and the highest class of actress live. It is filled with palaces, sprawling complexes, and it is near all of the main attractions of urban life. While the Imperial authorities are quite hands off here, the neighbourhood is organized and dominated by the Venetoi [ven-ET-ee] (Blues), a sports team turned mafia that handles the day-to-day business of half the city.



Figure 8 Horse Statues from Hippodrome, now in St. Marks Cathedral in Venice. Picture from World History Encyclopedia.

Prokopios/a [Pro-KOPE-ee-os/a]

Role: Demarkhos Venetōn [DEEM-arkh-os ven-et-ON] (Popular leader of Blues)

Gender: Any. -os ending for more masculine roles, -a ending for feminine

Infamous

Literacy: Up to player.

Description: Prokopios/a is one of the most powerful people in the city, but almost noone knows their name. They rose through the ranks of the Venetoi [ven-ET-ee] (Blues) circus faction, a group that began as a sports team and ended up something far closer to a Mafia, and established control of the organization. The siege is forcing them to come more into the open than they had in the past, though how open they will be about their role remains to be seen.

For the Veneti, the siege has not been a major disaster yet. They control the richer parts of town, which have always had a better food supply and water supply. In their part of town the siege seems distant and unthreatening, as the economy of the city continues to buzz along. Will this powerful person take control of the situation, using it to their advantage, or will they just continue as usual? And will they be able to survive as things become more desperate?

Choose this character if:

- You want to play a mob boss at the head of an ancient mafia
- You want to write a backstory of how your character ruthlessly seized power within an aristocratic mafia.
- You want a great deal of freedom to write your characters past, even the name is only a suggestion for this character.
- You want to deal with the consequences of having seized control and play a character that is infamous. Depending on how they are played, this could be a role with a high risk of dramatic character death.
- You want a character who works in the shadows and is almost entirely unconstrained by social expectations.
- Be involved in a culture that expects disagreements to be handled with knife fights.

Theodōros [the-OH-**th**oor-os**]**

Role: Kommerkiarios [kom-mer-kee-ar-EE-os] (commercial officer) for Woad.

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Respectable

Literacy: Functional, but not the bookish type.

Description: Theodoros is a civic official who has made himself quite wealthy through serving as a financial bureaucrat. He has used this wealth to create a wide variety of connections and a remarkable safety net. Unfortunately for him, he has now gained a level of prominence that results in being given more dangerous missions, such as collecting taxes from a rioting population or being part of a diplomatic mission to the Avars. He has also found himself gaining the attention of the Factions, and has been drawn against his will into the Blue faction's criminal underworld.

Aside from his work as the main tax collector for dye in the city, who he is and what he wants in the world are something of an enigma. Where does this newly rich man come from? What does he want? How far will he go? All of these are open questions.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a newly rich upstart who is finding his place in the city.
- To deal with the danger of having a lot of money without the social connections needed to protect it.
- To be involved in diplomatic exchanges and potentially high risk negotiations.
- To play a character whose backstory and future are almost entirely unconstrained.

Antōnina [and-oh-NEE-na]

Role: Hetaira [het-AY-ra] (Literally “Companion.” High Class Sex Worker, Musician, and/or Actress)

Gender: Mima [MI-ma] (Infamous Feminine Leaning Non-binary Role)

Infamous

Literacy: Spectacular. Entirely capable of memorizing entire epics.

Description: Antonina is the most famous (and infamous) companion in the city, and lauded throughout the city. She has been hired by most of the aristocrats in the city at one time or another. While her work is legally classed as infamia, and there are a wide number of scandalous rumours about her, mostly she finds herself working as musical and theatrical entertainment for private parties held by people with too much money. She has a reputation for being very expensive.

The siege has been a difficult time. The Church is using the threat of the Avars to preach against ‘Moral Corruption’. As usual, rather than target the men who hire her, they have targeted Antonia directly, preaching long, lurid, rants about her from the pulpits of the city. There is also opportunity in instability. A century before, another hetaira became Vasilissa [vas-il-IS-sa] (Empress) and left her mark on the entire empire. At the same time, other Hetaira have decided to leave the work and their lives behind, one of them even transitioned to becoming an evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role) and was lauded as a monastic Saint. Antonina is talented and could potentially shape a very different future for herself.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a glamorous actress with an infamous reputation.
- To wrestle with issues surrounding gender and objectification.
- To wrestle with issues surrounding a job that is condemned by a misogynistic church.
- To play a character that is first and foremost an artistic performer.
- To play a character whose prior connections and backstory are open to player development and who is not bound by social constraints.

Kosmas [kos-MAS]

Role: Camel Acrobat in the Hippodrome

Gender: Publicly presents as either Ephevos [EF-ee-vos] (Unmarried Masculine Role), or Mima [MI-ma] (Infamous Feminine Leaning Non-binary Role)

Infamous

Literacy: Proudly Illiterate! Your written secrets are safe with them.

Description: Kosmas is a larger than life minor celebrity. They have astounded people with their trick riding, death defying stunts, and wild escapades. The embodiment of 'here for a good time, not a long one', they have left a string of heartbroken fans, lovers, and rivals in their wake and are the subject of a ridiculous number of rumours.

They have few ambitions about the siege other than to survive it and do not much care about the politics of the city. Rather, Kosmas is concerned with their day to day life, accumulating wealth, having fun, and making connections to get new opportunities for their particular variety of cheerful mayhem. They have also worked for hire as a messenger for most of the notables in the city, and as a result have a great deal of access to the people and places of Konstantinoupolis.

Choose this character if you want:

- To just be a funny little guy, without any complications.
- To find ways to bring spectacle and comic relief to whatever scene you are in.
- To play someone primarily loyal to their own self-interest, but who is entirely capable of starting a riot if they decide to do so.
- To run messages and be involved in a wide variety of events, without being the centre of attention or a target.
- To play a street tough who comes from a tradition of (illegal) knife fights.
- To play a character whose background and connections are unconstrained and free for the player to shape.

Flavius Aetius [flav-ee-us ay-tee-us]

Role: Patrikios [pat-rik-EE-os] (Patrician, noble.)

Gender: Publicly presents as Aner [An-IR] (Adult Man)

Respectable

Literacy: Refuses to read or write in New Roman, and instead only writes in Latin.

Description: Flavius Aetius is the definition of a political dinosaur. The last patriarch of a family going back to the republican days of Rome, he is the kind of bore who will tell you at length how things used to be so much better back when his family had real power. Chauvinistic, entitled, and utterly misogynistic, Flavius represents the absolute worst of roman masculinity.

Twenty years ago, he personally helped Herakleios become ruler of the empire, in the hopes that he would restore senatorial power. Now that hope has vanished, and Flavius is bitterly angry at the Heraklian dynasty. Flavius sincerely hopes that Herakleios never comes home, and as the siege has developed has started looking for ways in which he might restore his family power.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a grumpy villain of a father in a way that people love to hate your character.
- To attempt to start a revolution that has almost no chance of success.
- To complain at length about how the young people today are ruining everything.
- To have a high chance of a dramatic death.
- To have a character who can illegally be armed and armored
- To play a character whose past connections are open to player development and who has decided that social constraints and expectations no longer apply to him.

Flavia [Flav-EE-a] **/ Velisarios** [vel-is-AR-ee-os]

Role: Rebellious Heiress

Gender: Parthenos [Par-THIN-os] (Unmarried Respectable Feminine Role), often presents as Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man).

Flavia is respectable. Velisarios is infamous.

Literacy: Her father has only allowed her to learn to read Latin. She resents this.

Description: Flavia is the definition of rebellious daughter. She is the only child of the Flavius family, and the last member of an ancient lineage. Her father, the Patrikios Flavius Aetius, has generally been neglectful and absent throughout her life, only truly present in the things that he has refused to let her do. She has decided that this should not be allowed to stop her from enjoying her life, and has developed an alter ego named Velisarios, who passes as a street tough and has enjoyed a wild range of escapades with the Venetoi in the last few years. Velisarios is everything Flavia is not. He is a nasty knife fighter, who drinks copiously, swears, and even wears those newfangled pants that were imported from Persia! Flavia has never felt so alive as when she embodies him.

The pressures of the siege are forcing her to decide which of these she wants to be. Neither the Venetoi nor her Father will take kindly to being deceived, so she could find herself in a good deal of trouble if she does not play her cards right. Her father also seems to be considering marriage offers, so her time of freedom may quickly come to an end. Will she stay Flavia, escape into Velisarios's more free life, or attempt to have part of both worlds?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play with disguises and alternate personalities.
- To engage with issues of how wealth and gender could trap people into certain social roles.
- To attempt to chart a path between societal expectation and wealth on the one hand, and freedom and poverty on the other.
- To engage with a culture that expects disagreements to be solved by knife fights.
- To play a character who has detailed connections and backstory for half their life, but whose alter ego has a great deal of room for player narrative when it comes to connection and escapades.
- Be involved in violent situations that could involve character injury or death

Georgia [yee-or-YEE-a]

Role: Patrikia [pat-rik-EE-a] (Patrician, noble.)

Gender: Gyne [gy-NEE] (Adult Respectable Feminine Role)

Respectable

Literacy: Exceptional. Her letters are some of the most artistic in the Roman language.

Description: Georgia is a widowed gyne in the prime of her life. She married a much older man, who died when she was quite young. Through some deft legal manoeuvring, she has retained all of her property, wealth, and has a high status title. She has become a major economic supporter of the Venetoi, and they leave her alone to pursue whatever life she wishes.

As the war and siege has developed, she has become worried about the future of the City. The increased authoritarianism and misogynistic preaching has not escaped her, and she has been exchanging a wide variety of letters with other people about the matter. She also has ambitions to be in the arts scene, which currently is entirely dominated by Sergios and the church. Her high status gives her access to the Palace as well as the rich neighbourhoods of town, so perhaps she can find allies there?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a self assured and powerful widow
- To attempt to organize literary Salons
- To engage with being in opposition to a misogynistic church, with a moderate chance of being targeted by them.
- To use charm and wealth to attempt to build a coalition of allies that guarantees your safety in the world.
- To play a character whose backstory and connections are significantly open to player development, and whose position in the world is relatively unconstrained.

Iōannēs Seismos [YANN-ees SEES-mos]

Role: Disgraced soldier turned enforcer.

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Infamous, formerly Military

Literacy: Illiterate except for reading numbers.

Description: Ioannes Seismos is a notorious former soldier and quartermaster who used to work for Bonos as the head quartermaster for the entire city. When the military reinforcements came to the city, he took a bribe and attempted to divert food from the military supplies to the Palace guards. An alliance of different civic officials, headed by the Patriarchēs Sergios, censured him for the action and he was removed from his position in disgrace.

Now, lucky to be alive, he has escaped into the underworld. There he has found a new role as an enforcer for the Venetoi, using his military training to break legs and collect debts. This is a job with a low life expectancy, and he knows it, and he dreams of finding a path to regaining his former status.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a disgraced former soldier who now works for the mafia.
- Be involved in violent situations as the main enforcer for the Blues.
- Have a moderate to high chance of having your character die dramatically
- Look for ways to clear your characters name and play political games to attempt to regain high status
- Illegally carry arms and armor.
- Be involved in a culture that expects disagreements to be handled with knife fights.

Theosophos/e [The-o-SOF-os or -ee]

Role: (Illegal) Wonder Worker

Gender: Any. -os ending for masculine presentations and -ee ending for feminine.

Infamous

Literacy: Multi-lingual in both current and dead languages. Can read any language.

Description: Theosophos/e is a shadowy figure in the life of the city. They have recently come from Egypt. They are decidedly strange, and anyone meeting them gets the feeling that this person has seen far too much in their pursuit of magical power. They have a collection of hieroglyphic covered papyri that only they can read, which they claim contain the secrets of ancient Egyptian magic. They have quickly gained a reputation as someone whose magic actually works.

In the siege, their power is in high demand, but so is the threat of exposure. The church actively condemns what Theosophos/e does, calling it the blackest of pagan magics. This does not stop people from hiring them, however, and they have done a wide variety of magical work, mostly involving curses and love spells. As fear ramps up in the siege, and as the power vacuum has deepened, they have only become more popular. Will they be able to stay ahead of their enemies in the church and enjoy this new prosperity?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a mysterious envoy for dark spirits and cause them to change the setting.
- To engage with the supernatural and magical aspects of the setting.
- To be a wonder worker for hire and get dragged into a wide variety of situations.
- To be a target of church persecution, with a quite high risk of being targeted with potentially deadly results.
- To play a character whose background and connections are largely open to player development and who lives unconstrained by social conventions.

Porphyrios [por-PHEER-ee-os]

Role: Charioteer

Gender: Publicly presents as Aner [An-IR] (Adult Man).

Infamous

Literacy: Illiterate.

Description: Porphyrios is the most famous charioteer of the last decade. He has ridden for all four factions and has an astounding number of racing victories. Lauded by the city, he has spent the last few years living the high life in between engaging in the extremely dangerous act of piloting a four horse chariot in the races. He lives life hard, as if each day could be his last, and is an absolute thrill seeker.

The war and the siege have directly affected his livelihood. There simply is not as much money for the races as there used to be, and as such the opportunities to perform have been getting fewer and farther between. Porphyrios is now in a position where they need to think about the future, and the sustainability of their lifestyle. He hates this.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a celebrity who lives in the moment and is the life of the party
- To engage with questions of thrill seeking and risky lifestyles
- To engage with a culture in which disagreements are often solved by knife fights
- To play a character caught between the two Factions, who is not loyal to either team.
- To play a character whose connections and background are heavily open to player development who is unconstrained by social expectations.

The Oxeia [ox-EE-a]

The Oxeia is one of the poorest neighborhoods in the city. It is high on a hill in between the harbors and the markets of the city. The aqueduct systems that supplied the areas water have long since run dry, and life here is hard. The people of Oxeia inhabit a shantytown built in and around the collapsing infrastructure of the region. Giant ten story tenement towers still command the landscape, interspersed with churches, markets, and defunct bath complexes. The people of the neighborhood squat in these urban remains, where they live in destitution. The neighborhood is dominated by the Prasinoi [pras-EEN-ee] (Greens), a sports team turned mob that has taken full control of the neighborhood and provides what passes for law and order in these dangerous streets.

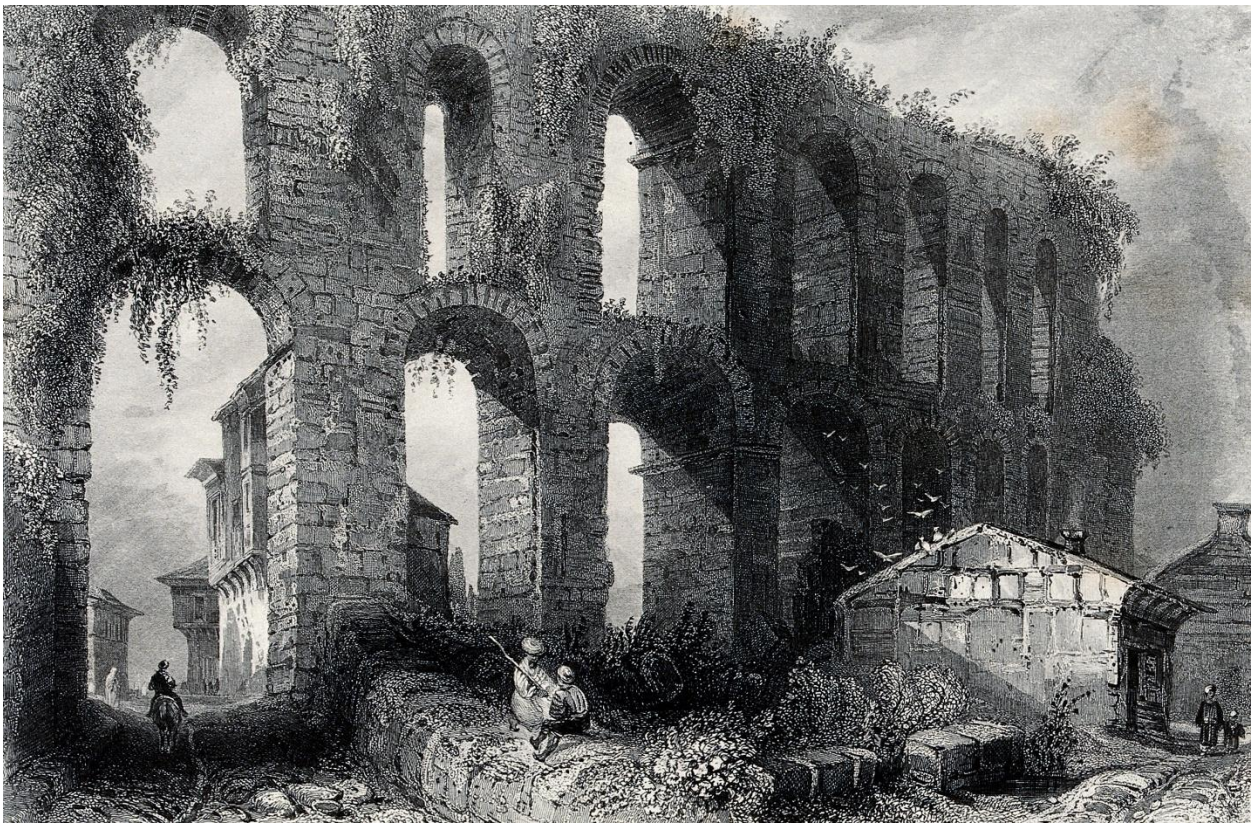


Figure 9 Aqueduct of Valens, 19th Century Engraving by Joseph Clayton Bentley, Wikimedia.

Alexandros Peradōn [al-ex-AND-rhos per-AD-on]

Role: Mob boss for the Prasinoi [pras-EEN-ee] (Greens)

Gender: Publicly presents as Aner [An-IR] (Adult Man).

Infamous

Literacy: Illiterate. Relies on Drosos and others for reading and writing**.**

Description: Alexandros came from the regional city of Perada a few years back, at the head of a small group of extremely tough characters. He then played a nasty game of back ally violence and legal politics to oust the leadership of the Prasinoi. He is feared more than he is respected, but keeps the Oxeia tightly under his control.

The siege is both an opportunity to advance his position within the world, and perhaps even go legit. It is also a dangerous time, the Oxeia is in trouble, and people are beginning to fear starvation and thirst more than they fear Alexandros. How will he navigate this environment, and will he maintain the loyalty of his faction?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a nasty street tough turned mob boss who has lived a life of crime.
- To be a violent character who is involved in violent scenes
- To be part of a culture that settles differences with knife fights
- To potentially be targeted for violence and have a high chance of dramatic death
- To play a character whose background and connections are open to player development, and who is largely unconstrained by social expectations.

Drosos [**TH**RO-sos]

Role: Kommentaresios [com-ment-ar-ES-ee-os] (Superintendant) for Alexandros.

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Respectable

Literacy: Competent, especially with numbers and legal writing.

Description: Drosos is the brains behind the Prasinoi operations. A longtime inhabitant of the Oxeia, he survived the various purges of the organization over the last years by maintaining a complex web of legal connections and by being useful to the tough men that ended up in charge. He knows almost everyone in the district, and a good number of the people in the richer parts of the city. Most of them owe him money.

The siege has been stressful for Drosos. The collapsing infrastructure hits directly at his entire network. There is less money in the system, the money means less, and the legal structures are starting to show the strain. The chances of a major popular uprising increase with every day there is not enough food. How does someone used to diplomatic conclusions to conflict handle a world that is increasingly violent?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play an underestimated but competent person within a machismo heavy mob.
- To navigate a culture of violence with words and bribes
- To be the person in the neighborhood who everyone knows, and have a wide variety of past connections.
- To be in a culture where disagreements are settled with knives, but not have that option yourself.
- To play a character whose background and connections are heavily predetermined but whose future is relatively unconstrained by social expectations.

Artemios [art-EM-ee-os]

Role: Eparkhēs [ep-ARKH-ees] (Leader) for Oxeia

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Respectable

Literacy: Competent in Roman and Latin.

Description: Artemios is the poor bastard who is officially in charge of the district. He handles low level legal disputes, is responsible for the impossible task of policing the district, and the even more impossible task of providing sufficient food and water to the place. In practice, this long suffering bureaucrat effectively is a figurehead for the Prasinoi who actually run the city.

The siege potentially is a chance to change the situation, though whether that will be for the better is highly questionable. If the local trust in the Prasinoi collapse, then perhaps outside forces might be able to help Artemios become leader of the neighborhood in truth. Or maybe it would be better to keep his head down, keep taking Drosos's bribes, and just worry about getting out of this job alive.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a long suffering bureaucrat in a nearly impossible job
- To try and use words, money, and legal power to keep control of a situation that is surrounded by violent solutions.
- To be involved in potential legal disputes.
- To play an outsider to the group that he is part of.
- To play a character who is heavily constrained by social position, but whose backstory and connections are open to player development.

Legion [lee-YEE-on]

Role: Daimonismenoi [**Th**ey-mon-ees-MEN-ee] (Possessed by Demons)

Gender: Multigender, depending on which demon is talking.

Infamous

Literacy: The demons know many languages. None of them are useful.

Description: Legion is one of the hordes of possessed that surround the churches of the Oxeia. Many of them are fakes, people who have realized that being possessed is a way to get fed and housed by the church, but Legion is the real deal. They have no memory of who they once were, just a succession of identities and urges that come from the supernatural world. Their life is a hard one, barely subsisting on the scraps they are given or steal, and all attempts to remove the demonic forces from them have failed.

The siege has been even harder. Food is more scarce, and the surplus that would be used as alms for the poor is gone. The demons have been ever louder, seeming eager for the chance to witness mass violence. What will happen to this demon-possessed body in the chaos of war?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a character who takes no responsibility for their own actions and who is living a marginal existence.
- To embody an inhuman personality as a character.
- To engage with themes of loss, memory, identity, and disjointed personalities.
- To engage with the supernatural constantly as a core part of the character.
- To be involved in exorcism scenes
- To play a character whose backstory is heavily open to player development, and who has low social expectations.

Maria [Mah-REE-ah]

Role: Xenodokheia [xen-o-**th**oh-KHEE-ah] (Innkeeper and Matron)

Gender: Gyne [gy-NEE] (Adult Respectable Feminine Role)

Infamous

Literacy: Illiterate.

Description: Maria has lived a hard and tulmultuous life. Born into poverty in the regions, she turned sex work at an inn beside the main miliary role into a remarkably successful business. She outmanuevered the men around her, and ended up the sole owner of a property. She then managed to, despite laws prohibiting it, marry a very old and very powerful local magistrate, who then proceeded to die, leaving her a wealthy and respectable widow, despite her past.

The last year has been hard. Her city was attacked by Persian armies in the year before, and she only just escaped in time with a great deal of portable wealth. Now in the city, she has used her wealth to buy an inn very much like the one she used to work at. She now portrays herself as a respectable widow to all who talk to her, but secretly owns and operates a variety of infamous businesses.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a savvy business woman who has made the most of a very hard life.
- To lead a double life as both a criminal and a respectable widow.
- To play host and attempt to make other characters feel welcome and appreciated in your space.
- To play a character with a wide variety of access to different levels of society.
- To play a character who uses economic power and persuasion to get what she wants.
- To play a character that is likely to find herself in conflict with the church.
- To play a character whose connections are highly open to player development and whose role within the world is relatively unconstrained.

Xeno [XEE-noh]

Role: Iatros [ee-AT-rhos] (Doctor)

Gender: Publicly either Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role).

Infamous

Literacy: If it exists in Konstantinoupolis, he can read it.

Description: Xeno is a foreigner, originally from the Persian world. His name was considered unpronouncible by the inhabitants of the city, so he has accepted that his new identity is the Roman word for foreigner. He is certainly not a Christian, and what exact religion he follows is something that he keeps quite guarded. What he does say is that he learned how to heal at the very best schools in northern Persia, and he has sworn an oath to only heal.

The siege has become a dangerous time for Xeno, as suspicion of easterners has increased heavily. It has also been profitable, the rate of injuries and the desperation for care has only increased as the war has gotten worse. The church has also become increasingly hostile, and he worries that they will target his business.

Play this character if you want:

- To engage in medical roleplay and the aftermath of violence.
- To engage with heavy themes of being one of the only non-Roman characters in the city.
- To potentially be targeted by religious persecution that could have deadly results.
- To play a character that has very few social expectations, but who is operating in a heavily precarious environment.
- To learn about the Sassanian Persian world and embody foreignness.
- To play a character whose connections are heavily open to player interpretation and development.

Menas [Me-NAS]

Role: Wine Merchant from Egypt

Gender: Publicly presents as Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role)

Respectable

Literacy: Illiterate

Description: Menas is a successful merchant captain from Alexandria, in Egypt. He has built an economic empire shipping wine and grain from the Nile to the hungry capital. A spendthrift man of modest tastes, he has turned an abandoned building in the poorest part of town into an efficient warehouse that is easily fortifiable. He has longstanding connections with both the Prasinoi and the Venetoi circus factions.

As the war worstened, the source of his livelihood has been cut off. As the Persian armies closed in on Alexandria, Menas liquidated everything he had in the city, bought every ship he could, and led one last food and grain fleet to Konstantinoupolis. He has been hoarding that food ever since, selling it at an incredible mark up. This makes him both an important figure in the city, and someone that is deeply resented by many of the inhabitants of the city.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a cutthroat merchant who will protect his wealth by any means possible
- To engage with themes of being an outsider to the city in a highly dangerous time
- To use economic support and diplomatic connections to attempt to survive in a hostile environment
- To have wide ranging connections centered on economic exchange
- To play a character whose backstory and connections are heavily open to player interpretation and whose position is relatively unconstrained by social expectations.

Petros [PET-rhos]

Role: Blacksmith

Gender: Publicly presents as Anēr [an-EER] (Adult Man) or Evnoukhos [Ev-NOO-khos] (Masculine Leaning Non-binary Role)

Respectable

Literacy: Illiterate.

Description: Petros is a no nonsense craftsperson who is known for solid reliable work. They are famous in the area for their cheap and effective metalwork, and generally are seen as a reliable and stable pillar of the Oxeia's social community. They are slow to anger, but the stories of what happens when they are crossed are the stuff of whispered folk legends. Like everyone else in the Oxeia, they have a relationship with the Prasinoi, who regularly make use of their services in makeshift weapons making and in cheap parts for the chariots.

In the siege, Petros has found steady employment with the military, providing them with weapons and armor. The new connections that this has made mean that they have options they never considered in the past. Does Petros/a stay in their role as a pillar of local community in the poorest part of town, or do they attempt to move up in the world and leave the Oxeia behind them?

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a solid craftsperson who is well liked within the community.
- Engage in roleplay centering around blacksmithing and the production of weapons
- Have good connections with both the Mob and the Military
- Play a character that is moderately likely to end up in violent situations
- Reluctantly engage with a culture that settles disputes with knife fights
- Have a great deal of freedom for establishing backstory and connections and have few social constraints.

Anna Kharites [ANN-ah khar-EE-tees]

Role: Religious Widow

Gender: Gyne [gy-NEE] (Adult Respectable Feminine Role)

Respectable

Literacy: Illiterate

Description: Anna is a very old and very pious woman who spends most of her days in acts of charity and volunteering her time for the Church of Ioannos Prodromos in the Oxeia. She goes there every day, refills and lights the lamps, and prays to the icon of St Artemios [art-ee-MEE-os], a saint who is famous for their healing miracles. Miraculous things happen around her, though she seems completely oblivious to her affect on the world.

She lives in a charity home that she has created, giving shelter to those less fortunate than herself. The siege has been hard, especially the loss of water, but she does not seem to have noticed and lives out her days in pious ritual.

Choose this character if you wish to:

- Play a generous and kindhearted older character
- Play with heavy religious themes and be involved in religious ritual
- Play with the supernatural and ‘accidentally’ cause miracles to happen around you
- Have social connections with most of the femme characters within the game
- Play a character whose backstory is highly open to player interpretation and who has few social expectations.

Ioanna Maxima [ee-o-AN-na max-EE-ma]

Role: Former Slave, Parent.

Gender: Mima [MI-ma] (Infamous Feminine Leaning Non-binary Role)

Infamous

Literacy: Reads Latin, but not modern Roman.

Description: Ioanna has lived a very hard life. She was captured by pirates when she was young, sold into slavery, and then eventually found herself heavily enmeshed in the Prasinoi. Originally from Italy, she still reads latin, a skill that is of occasional use to her mob connections. She is a hard woman who knows her way around both the use of weapons and poisons. After decades of sex work, she has found her way to living in the safe house provided by Anna Kharites and has developed a close friendship with the widow.

As the siege has settled in, Ioanna faces a personal dilemma, namely that her daughter Euphemia has come of age. Life is hard in the Oxeia, and so far Ioanna has protected Euphemia from that reality. This looks likely to change, however, and Ioanna is increasingly desperate to find a way to prevent her daughter's life from looking like her own.

Choose this character if you want:

- To play a parent who has seen the worst life has to offer
- To engage with heavy themes of a past involving slavery and coercion
- To be part of a community of femme characters and have a wide variety of femme connections.
- To be involved in a culture that solves disagreement with knives, or poisons.
- To possibly be involved in violent scenes.
- To play a character whose backstory is heavily open to player development and who has few social expectations.

Euphemia [Ev-fee-MEE-ah]

Role: Infamous by Birth, Daughter.

Gender: Mima [MI-ma] (Infamous Feminine Leaning Non-binary Role)

Infamous.

Literacy: None.

Description:

Euphemia was born trapped. Her mother's life was incredibly hard, and Euphemia was legally declared to be infamous from the moment she was born. The world has been at war for her entire life, food has often been scarce, and life is hard. The only points of joy have come from the patronage and company of Anna Kharites, who has housed both Euphemia and her parent, and who even cured Euphemia of Bubonic plague.

Euphemia has some very dark memories, but the last few years have been ok. The siege, and her coming of age, threaten the world that she lives in. They also leave her very torn. She knows the stories of figures like Theodora, the sex worker who became empress, and she sees the potential for glamour working for the Prasinoi. She also knows that both Anna and her parent are deeply afraid for her, and want her to live a better life. But she also knows that wish won't put food on the table. So, she is torn, and unsure what she will do.

Choose this character if you want to:

- Play a character who has almost no power and is trapped by her birth into a low legal status
- Engage with heavy themes including potential for slavery and coercion
- Try and navigate a world through words and wit alone.
- Have connections primarily with femme characters.
- Play a character whose backstory is short and who has few social expectations.



Solidus of Herakleios and Herakleios Konstantinos, Acropolis Museum, Greece.